The Patient

By Louise Heck-Rabi

INTRODUCTION

Until 1968 the use of the term "race riot" in the United States referred to race riots which were often a mob action by members of the majority racial group against people of other races. In the late 1960s the term Race Riots came to describe riots involving large numbers of members of racial minority groups. Physical aggression was often aimed at neighborhood business, government representatives and law enforcement agencies perceived as unfairly targeting racial groups. The National Advisory Commission on Civil Disorders (the Kerner Commission) reported 130 separate race riots in the summer of 1967—initiated by blacks in response to police brutality, poor housing, no jobs, and exclusion from the benefits and promises of American life. It became a true revolution of rising expectations. In the Patient by Louise Heck-Rabi, a young girl, recounts the events leading up to her involvement in one such riot. Meet Susannah Lynn, who speaks to us from her room in a mental hospital. When you hear her story, you will understand why. The Patient by Louise Heck-Rabi

SUSANNAH: Miz Lydia's house looked good from the alley. Its backside better than the picture of the Courthouse downtown. White, tall up into heaven, clean and good-smelling as the laundry I delivered twice a week in my wagon. The Askew family wash was a precious cargo worth two or three dollars. Ma had a sign in front of our house: WASHING AND IRONING. She boiled the clothes and beat them with the paddle she used on us. She could iron fast! Nine white men's shirts, long sleeves, in an hour.

Miz Askew liked Ma's work. She like me first time she saw me on the veranda off the kitchen, waiting till the housekeeper

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counted pieces, me wondering 'bout that smell of molasses just baked and warm. I skipped to the veranda corner finding three pans laid out to cool. Raisin-face cookies. Staring and hoping to steal-"What is your name, child?" I turned like a top, bent my knees like Ma said, and looked up at her. "Susannah Lyme. Ma'am." She was the cleanest, coolest looking lady I'd ever seen. "How many are there at home?" she asked, putting my name after it, "Susannah," like it was special. I lied. "Five," I said, looking at the cookies. The housekeeper come out the door with three dollars in her hand. "Fanny, please. You will give Susannah seven cookies to take home." Fanny gave me the dollars and a hard look, then went back in, letting the screened door slam this time.

"I am Mrs. Askew," she told me what I already suspicioned. I made half a curtsey. "Yes, Ma'am." The bag in Fanny's hands crackled with the cookies' weight. "How old are you, Susannah?" she asked next. "Twelve," I spoke up, "Miz Askew." My middle grew tight like it did before tests in school. Still, I felt good with her. We stood there awhile just looking at each other till Fanny folded the top of the bag and cleared her throat. Miz Askew thanked her. I got the cookies. And still she considered me like I was something special she could figure out with her china-blue eyes. "On Saturdays, sometimes on Sunday afternoons, I give large dinner parties. Please ask your mother

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if you could help at table and with Fanny in the kitchen." Even before she finished I blurted out, "Oh, Miz Askew! I'm sure it'll be alright! So long as it don't interfere with my schoolin'." She smiled then and so did I. "You will ask her permission?" Those words soft as dandelion fluff under the smile. I nodded. "Yes, Miz Askew." She turned. So did I. Almost forgot! "Thank you for the cookies, Miz Askew." She really smiled then. "Please tell your mother that you were given two instead of one, as a reward for your work in pulling the wagon." Her face didn't change. I knew we had a special understanding. And I would die if Ma didn't let me wait table for her. Ma did. But I couldn't fall behind in my homework because of my jobs. I still had to deliver laundry on weekdays. But every cent I earned went into my very own bank account. Imagine! An education fund! Ma said I was the best learner in the whole school, about as smart as Waldo, her oldest, never saw him till I was in college.

Waiting table at the Askew's made living easier. I took home food and clothes that didn't fit. I took home memories of seven course dinners for twenty guests lasting three hours. Fanny and the rest of us could do without Mr. Askew, a red-faced ox with heavy feet and heavier voice. Miz Lydia said we could call her that. She called me Sukey, saying it suited me. We marveled at her powers of sweetness to endure him. He'd put you straight if the soup was cool! We hated him. Loved her. Those were the

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best years of my life, so busy I could hardly feel the seasons changing on my face. I sang in the choir, I played a maid in the Senior play. I was elected to the National Honor Society. I was cheerleader, I helped Ma wash and iron clothes, yet I treasured most my hours with Miz Lydia. I deposited my money in the bank (Ma wouldn't let me take any out). I was going to college-at least for a year. I would have to work, but I was used to it. I wanted to be somebody, wanted to raise Ma up out of that cellar, away from the copper boiler forever. But I was afraid to leave Ma and Miz Lydia. I couldn't fathom how I would live without those four o'clock Sunday dinners where the race question was discussed when I was in the pantry or the kitchen, and hushed when I came in. But I heard plenty!

Miz Lydia kept tellin' me I was tops. She wrote letters of recommendation. She said I could be anything I wanted to be, if I sought it and fought for it. She meant working, studying, praying, not messin' around on the front porch on warm spring nights. She meant not having boyfriends like Doremus and Geneva, she meant ignoring the hoot-calls of every man any color who looked you over in the street.

A leather-bound address book with the address of the Askew's written in it, and a five dollar bill was my goingaway-to-college gift. Miz Lydia gave it to me herself. She looked confused, her eyes

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clouding up, but still smiling. She took both my hands. "Remember me, Sukey. This door (it had to be the back door, I knew that) is open to you, always. Write to me. Come if you need work or help. My hands are tied in many ways (that was the ox, Mr. Askew, Lord-of-the-Manor, Nigger-hater, who knew Negroes, including me, hated him). There are times when I cannot do as I choose." I mumbled thanks, stumbled down the steps, my legs too long for the sidewalk. Too long for the undersized desks in the classrooms of Belmont College, one of those all-black little Southern institutions, trying its best, oh Lord, to educate. I worked in the Library. I lived in a room. I studied. Everything came easy. My straight *A's* put me on the Dean's List. I clipped the List from the paper and mailed it home to Ma. I might get a tuition scholarship! I was lonely and homesick, but ready for new worlds.

At student mixers I chewed chips, drank beer, got absorbed in discussions of politics, pacifism, civil rights. I attended forums, rallies, symposia. I read about the riots, the Mississippi murders, I boarded the College bus one Friday to go to a sit-in at the Public Library the next two towns over, where stand-up only service was the rule for Negroes. My first taste of violence was the ice water from the firehoses aimed at us. The local jail was crowded and too small, our sentences light, all of us back to Monday classes like nothing happened. I never wrote Ma or Miz Lydia about my adventures, I did write about my job, my profs, about Neal, his friends

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who organized bus rides to march with banners in D.C. picketing Air Force bases and submarine launchings. My own participation much less-I had to work! I promised Neal I'd demonstrate at home on Easter vacation, for open housing. We heard rumors of real trouble-but Neal claimed, "Always rumors, doll. Don't believe it!" Doremus and Geneva said No when I asked them to demonstrate with us. And meet Neal. I walked alone to the Church basement, seeing the College bus in the parking lot. We got instructions. Neal's words were, "March and sing at the home of the Housing Commissioner." I held a banner and his hand.

Oh No! Not that beautiful white Georgian-style mansion I knew so well! I couldn't walk. I stumbled, swayed. The police watched us. We circled outside that tall iron fence, singing the words Neal had written to the tune of "Dixie." They say they will never know who threw the firebomb that exploded at the front door. Pow! Like that. Seems everybody was just waiting for that sound to let loose, to rampage like animals from opened cages, a signal to throw our candles toward the house, to push through the closed gates, scale the fence, to scream. More explosions-what were they?-shattered my ears. No, no, not this house, not even if old ox-faced Askew was Housing Commissioner! "What's the matter, Sukey? Get with it!" Neal yelled. He rushed me along, police closing in on us, some on horses. I smelled smoke. The house was burning! Staring, I saw servants' faces framed in the windows with flames behind them.

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Oh, Miz Lydia! I am your Sukey! Do you understand? Do you know I'm not to blame? Brick throwing started. Why? Neal dragged me down. In an ocean, surging, Neal and I, in a body-pressed wave swirling to that pillared veranda double front doors, wood a-smoking, windows smashing. Miz Lydia, where are you? It was Monday. No dinner in the oval dining room for twenty guests today! Run our, Miz Lydia! Go out back! Won't see you! Let old ox-face get his due, but not you! Please, God! Not you!

Crack! A pistol shot stunned the air, stopped Time, as if the voice of God had spoken one holy word. "Look!" Neal pointed, with pride, "That white bastard's shot!" Snowflakes melted in my open mouth, my eyes stuck on old Ox-face himself, in the shrubs at the side of the house! Askew trying to run away! Like flies buzzin' a wave surged toward him, police swinging billy sticks, horses' hooves making muck of the Askew lawn. "Some screwball's got a gun!" someone shouted. I screamed. There was my Miz Lydia! Cool and clean like always, running out from that veranda side door pulling on her coat, dipping her chin against thickening snow. Did she see ox-face? Did the rage of the mob scare her? She paused as if deciding these questions, then ran. I called out to warn her, "Miz Askew! Go back! Miz Askew! Go back!" Her face turned-did she hear me?-Neal turned, angry, astonished. Crack! She fell in a heap! My arms stretched out to her, dropped from my sight by a shot from an anonymous pistol! "I've got to help her! Let me go! I've got

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to get to Miz Lydia!" I shouted. Neal held on to me. I wrestled him, broke free, struggled through the smell of sweaty bodies, forced myself into the ring of black bodies leaning over her, not helping. Oh God! Let me die so she can live! I struggled closer just as cops rode closer, billy sticks swinging. I held both her hands, blood from her back, when the first blow swished my head. I screamed so hard I could not close my mouth. On my knees I cradled her, the next blow hit harder, blood trickling from my chest. I'm sorry, Miz Lydia, I'm sorry, I whispered in my own echo chamber, I didn't know, I didn't know, I hurt, I hurt! Oh please God, let me die so she can live! Oh please God, let me die so she can live!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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